Become a more **EFFECTIVE HR EXECUTIVE**

Draw on some of Peter Drucker's insights to grow yourself as an HR practitioner.

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Anyone who stops learning is old, whether at twenty or eighty. Anyone who keeps learning stays young. The greatest thing in life is to keep your mind young." Henry Ford

One of the most significant determinants of an organisation's success in the current global village is the effective management of its human resources. As Jeffrey Pfeffer said in his book, Competitive Advantage Through People, "If competitive success is achieved through people, then the skills of those people are significant." We could then add, "What about those who are handling, leading and managing those people?" By that, we mean HR Practitioners or Executives!

HR people are consistently under the microscope. They are the scapegoast for other executives, and are blamed if they cannot get the right people at the right time or when staff turnover jumps high. They have to fix the low morale, increase staff satisfaction and, probably, have to be magicians with a bag full of tricks to provide solutions to all enquiries, challenges and issues.

In addition, many CEOs aren't happy with the performance and deliverables of their HR function, and undoubtedly they will never be. There are so many reasons that hinder being effective and efficient in managing the function.

During my journey as an HR executive, trainer, speaker and lecturer in different countries, I have

received comments and complaints from HR practitioners like, 'My CEO doesn't know what HR is doing or doesn't understand it.'

CEOs are challenging their HR practitioners to redefine their roles and their contribution to the company. How often are the top human resources executives involved in discussions of opening new markets, acquisitions and shareholder value? Not very often, I guess.

In general, CEOs want their HR people to have enthusiasm for the business, a strong presence among their peers, professional compatibility with top executives, and down-to-earth practicality. They hear lots of talk, and see limited results.

We are still seeing HR practitioners talking about morale, satisfaction and motivation without converting those words into numbers and impact areas. This is far from what CEOs want.

To move HR practitioners forward let us ask naïve questions about where their time goes.

The majority of HR executives spend their time fixing issues, fire-fighting, solving the problems of other executives, record keeping and shuffling papers. Most of what they engage in has no impact on the company.

As Peter Drucker said in The Practice of Management (1954), "The constant worry of all personnel administrators is their inability to prove that they are making a contribution to the enterprise. Their preoccupation is with the search for a 'gimmick' that will impress their management associates. Their persistent complaint is that they lack status."

Wonder why HR practitioners are not at the executive table?

However, very few serious HR executives will tell you that they spend their time developing programmes to enhance organisational efficiency or updating performance management systems. The Center for Effective Organisations at the University of Southern California, revealed survey results in 2012 about how HR spends its time:

- Maintaining records 13.6%;
- Auditing & Controlling 12.5%;
- Providing human resources services 30.4%;
- Developing HR systems and practices 16.7%; and
- Acting as a strategic business partner 26.8%.

However, you will be surprised to see that none of them develop themselves!

Despite the fact that there is clearly a need for HR to assist in the vital people dimension of corporate strategy, only a few CEOs believe that the head of HR is a key player in strategic planning. The majority of MDs and CEOs I have asked have no clue of what the key drivers of human performance are and what the HR function will and will not do.

To this end, how can HR practitioners develop an effective HR function that manages the current working environment and earn their seat at the executive table?

HR practitioners need to focus on what they do. Peter Drucker suggests the following actions in his book The Effective Executive:

- Concentrate on one thing at a time and delegate the rest;
- Your activities favour your company and whatever you do must benefit your organisation, "owners, management and the employees" forget about your comfort zone; and
- Prepare a detailed action plan, communicate it to the concerned people and make sure that your plan is working appropriately.

Regrettably, the majority of practitioners actually conspire against their personal efficiency, due to the following five obstacles or habits:

1. Managing time;
2. What can I contribute?
3. Working on strengths;
4. Setting objectives and priorities; and
5. Making decisions.

So, how can HR practitioners overcome those obstacles?

Managing time

Time is a scary resource – unless it is managed, nothing else can be managed. Besides the basic things that we all know about time management and time wasters, I believe that the Open Door Policy is one of the major time wasters if not defined properly.

The open door policy is the one that employees can easily abuse or take advantage of by wishing to skip going through their immediate supervisor and go

straight to the top even if the issue at hand does not call for it. HR may get bogged down with tedious problems. Another disadvantage is that the regular appearance of employees at the HR office can because a disruption in the flow of the workplace.

You may like to apply the time management grid that was introduced by S Covey to organise your time based on activities as Drucker said, "You cannot manage the time, and you can only manage yourself."

Contribution

HR practitioners ought to focus on what issues need to be achieved – not what work needs to be done, nor the techniques and tools involved.

To do that you need to review various things such as organisational vision, mission and values, as well as the annual business plan and the strategic plan, if available. Apply the concept of management by walking around to get the feeling of what you could contribute.

HR practitioners have to move away from needless bureaucratic, obstructionist, filling out forms and other trivial tasks, to being more business people oriented.

Strengths

Build on strengths, not weaknesses. Build on your strengths and those of your colleagues. Focus on what you can do and ignore what you can't do. You need to critically evaluate yourself and get to know your strengths. Perhaps you may need to ask your colleagues, if in doubt. Identify your strengths and choose one of your strengths to focus on according to its importance to your organisation.

Objectives and priorities: 'First things first'

Concentrate on the few things that will produce the greatest results and get rid of unnecessary activities. Apply a Management by Objectives model. Don't be overwhelmed with new HR concepts and themes that may not work for your organisation. Set your objectives and priorities.

Analyse the working environment, culture and whom you are working with, as well as decision making and process. As a matter of fact, analysing the company 'Health Check' will provide a clear picture of what and where you can contribute and set objectives on priority basis.

Decision-making

Make decisions and implement them by seeking dissenting opinions – not seeking consensus. Make the best fundamental decisions, and focus on the right strategy. Being able to differentiate generic situations from the strange ones is the key to effective executive decision-making.

When financial turmoil struck organisations in 2008/2009, downsizing, layoffs and salary reductions were the primary solutions for the majority of organisations. My decision as CHRO was to keep the people and do something else.

The following actions were taken:

1. Freeze hiring;
2. Gradually reduce all cash benefits (mobile and gasoline allowance);
3. Travelling economy class for all members with no exceptions;
4. Renegotiating medical plans;
5. Re-routing staff transportation;
6. Office utilities to be turned off completely;
7. Reducing working hours to six instead of eight for management members;
8. Vacation balance to be consumed. No carrying over;
9. Permitting leave without pay for a maximum of 60 days;
10. Revisiting overtime policy for possible inclusion of new grades;
11. Studying the feasibility of working two shifts of 10 to 12 hours each instead of three shifts;
12. Implementing critical staff evaluation with involvement of HR staff to ensure fairness decisions;
13. Laying off staff based on performance deficiency only:
    - Last in first out;
    - Employees under probation period;
    - Employees under one year;
    - Other members; and
14. Studying critical medical causes of high bills.

Finally, your own development as an effective HR executive is central to the development and performance of the organisation. Any executive working toward becoming effective raises the performance level of the whole organisation. ■

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